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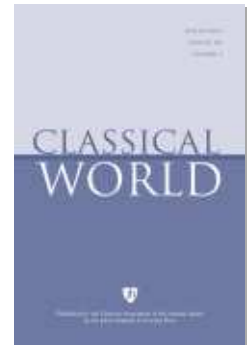
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Abel Tamas

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The Morphological Metamorphosis of Thetis in Catullus' Poem 64

ÁBEL TAMÁS

ABSTRACT: This paper examines the famous polyptoton (*Thetidis . . . Thetis . . . Thetidi*) in Catullus' poem 64.19–21 and interprets it as a morphological realization of Thetis' metamorphosis, which—along with the whole negative side of the myth—is suppressed in the Catullan narrative. This “morphological metamorphosis” is, according to this paper, part of Catullus' play with narrative and (inter)textual illusions in his miniature epic.

Visuality and perception are “hot topics” with regard to Catullus' miniature epic, which permanently tries to delude both its characters and readers. In that regard, Catullus' poem 64 is the predecessor of “Ovid's poetics of illusion,”¹ with its metaleptic narrative deceiving our perception so much that we sometimes cannot decide if we are reading an “Argonautica” or another kind of epic project; if we are in the first or the second narrative level of the poem; if we are in or out of the ecphrasis; and so forth.² The Catullan poetics of illusion is strongly interconnected with the “textile” motives and metaphors of the poem, suggesting a notion of textuality that is based on the interweaving of various narrative, inter- and intratextual threads which sometimes appear, sometimes disappear, in the Catullan textual fabric.³ Therefore, the text of poem 64 becomes its own metaphor, to the effect that its reflections of its own material surface are going to be constitutive of the construction of poetic meaning.

This notion of textuality, as I will argue here, is in some sense illustrated in the first scene of the poem,⁴ where—surprisingly “changing” the subject of

¹ See P. Hardie, *Ovid's Poetics of Illusion* (Cambridge 2002).

² See J. H. Gaisser, “Threads in the Labyrinth: Competing Views and Voices in Catullus 64,” *AJP* 116 (1995) 579–616, rpt. in J. Gaisser, ed., *Catullus. Oxford Readings in Classical Studies* (Oxford 2007) 217–18; E. Theodorakopoulos, “Catullus, 64: Footprints in the Labyrinth,” in A. Sharrock and H. Morales, eds., *Intratextuality: Greek and Roman Textual Relations* (Oxford 2001) 115–41.

³ For the textual and textile metaphors of poem 64, see esp. J. Scheid and J. Svenbro, *The Craft of Zeus: Myths of Weaving and Fabric*, C. Volk, tr. (Cambridge, Mass 1996) 83–107; T. J. Robinson, “Under the Cover of Epic: Pretexts, Subtexts and Textiles in Catullus' Carmen 64,” *Ramus* 35 (2006) 29–62.

⁴ For some parts, esp. the proem of poem 64, as an “Argonautica,” see J. B. DeBrohun, “Catullan Intertextuality: Apollonius and the Allusive Plot of Catullus 64,” in M. B. Skinner, ed., *Blackwell Companion to Catullus* (Malden, Mass. 2007) 293–313.

the poem from “Argonautica” into “Peleus and Thetis”—Peleus catches sight of Thetis, and allegedly falls in love with her. I cite only the lines that describe the second half of the scene:⁵

illa, atque <haud> alia, uiderunt luce marinas
mortales oculis nudato corpore Nymphas
nutricum tenus exstantes e gurgite cano.
tum Thetidis Peleus incensus fertur amore,
tum Thetis humanos non despexit hymenaeos,
tum Thetidi pater ipse iugandum Pelea sensit.

(64.16–21)

That was the day, never matched, when mere mortals witnessed
marine nymphs rising up from the dappled sea surge,
mother-naked to breasts and below. It was then that Peleus—
so goes the story—burned up with love for Thetis,
then that Thetis did not reject a human marriage,
then that the Father himself felt Peleus and Thetis should wed.

There is a strong emphasis on perception in this description, explicitly in *uiderunt* (“they have seen,” 1), but implicitly in *despexit* and *sensit* as well, which, in spite of the actual, figurative usage, both carry their original meaning, connected to (visual) perception and strengthened by the context itself. Similarly, *luce* here means “day,” but juxtaposed with *uiderunt*, we cannot forget its primary meaning (“light”), which also suggests a connection to visibility. In spite of its association with knowledge and truth, visibility, as is well-known, sometimes serves as a medium of delusion, questioning the truthfulness of human perception. The narrator, while speaking about perception, achieves narrative delusion: at the beginning, he suggests that we are reading a Catullan “Argonautica,” but after this we are informed—as the emphatic threefold anaphora and polyptoton in 19–21 reinforce—that what is being started here is a “Peleus and Thetis” poem, and the question remains: is it or is it not? “Theseus and Ariadne,” not “Peleus and Thetis,” are the subject of the overwhelming ecphrasis.⁶

Moreover, the truth of the Catullan words is dubious, because the mythological and poetic tradition knows the story differently: by all accounts, Thetis did not want to marry Peleus—on the contrary, she tried everything to escape this marriage.⁷ Additionally, there is a variant of this scenario, documented before Ovid only in visual representation, in which the unwilling Thetis, when attacked by Peleus, uses the device of metamorphosis, that is, changing her shape in a Protean way, in order to escape the sexual affair with Peleus.⁸ The authority

⁵ Translated by P. Green, ed., *The Poems of Catullus* (Berkeley 2005).

⁶ Gaisser (above n.2) 219 says, “The impression [that is, that the subject of the poem is the voyage of the Argonauts] is allowed to stand until the poem’s true subject is revealed—or seems to be—in the elegant and arresting threefold polyptoton of 19–21.”

⁷ C. J. Fordyce, ed., *Catullus: A Commentary* (Oxford 1961), 19.

⁸ For the (later) texts, see Ovid. *Met.* 11.238–246; Apoll. *Bibl.* 1.13.5. As for visual representations of Thetis’ metamorphosis, consider primarily Peithinos’ red-figure kylix

formula of *fertur* in 19 (“so goes the story”) has been recently interpreted as an ironic “Alexandrian footnote”: the usual sign of allusion here means the contrary, namely that there is no hint of the willing Thetis in the previous poetic tradition.⁹ *Fertur* as a sign of fictionality is especially interesting in the context of 16–17, where Catullus claims that he knows the only authentic version of another moment in the story: “That was the day, never matched, when mere mortals witnessed | marine nymphs rising up from the dappled sea surge.” Contrarily, the report implied in *fertur*—reinforced by the anaphora of *tum* in 19–21 (“it was then . . . then . . . then”)—seems to be the one that is specifically inauthentic.¹⁰

Hence, the emphasis on visibility in this scene seems to go hand in hand with narrative untruthfulness in two different ways: we know neither which story is being told (“Argonautica,” “Peleus and Thetis,” or something else?), nor if we should give credit to this previously undocumented “love story” of the goddess and the mortal hero. Accordingly, there is a strong textual pun in the text—and this is what I want to highlight here—based on the visual perception of the reader, reflecting his or her situation vis-à-vis these narrative delusions. We are told that Thetis wanted to marry Peleus without any hesitation. At the same time, we perceive visually a textual event, specifically contradicting this variant: the threefold polyptoton (*Thetidis . . . Thetis . . . Thetidi*), which is commonly taken as Alexandrian mannerism¹¹ as well as a sign of the peculiarity of this narrative,¹² is in fact a morphological metamorphosis of Thetis. Thetis’ polyptoton, on the textual surface, accomplishes the event which is denied in the narrative—Thetis’ mythological shape-shifting—and at the same time, plays with the dangers of delusion implied in visual perception. Peleus catches sight of Thetis, but does not know anything about his chances, while we are told that the chances are extremely good (“Thetis did not reject a human marriage,” 21). But we see something different: Thetis, or more precisely her *name*, is changing her (grammatical) form, making a visual effect, which, for an (illusory?) moment, changes the words into some kind of picture, exploiting and performing the “pictorialism” embedded in the textual medium as well as in the “ecphrastic poetics” of poem 64.¹³ This is the textual and pictorial completion of the narrative

(ARV2, 115.2, 1626; Para, 332; Beazley Addenda 2.174) from ca. 500 B.C. Although, however, there is no clear trace of Thetis’ metamorphosis in textual sources before Ovid, there are suggestions in Pind. *Nem.* 4.62 of “fire” and “lion” as obstacles of the marriage of Peleus and Thetis, which—in light of later tradition—can be interpreted as early hints of shape-changing; compare W. B. Henry (*Pindar’s Nemeans: A Selection: Edition and Commentary* [Munich and Leipzig 2005], 41, 62–64) who comments, “[t]he present passage and S. fr. 150.2 . . . are the earlier references in literature to Thetis’ metamorphoses.”

⁹ DeBrohun (above, n.4) 299; see also Gaisser (above, n.2) 221 on the same function of *dicuntur* in v. 1.

¹⁰ DeBrohun (above, n.4) 299 writes, “For here Catullus uses *fertur* when reporting an event whose timing, which the poet emphasizes with the first *tum* of an anaphoric trio, Catullus himself appears to have invented, in direct contradiction to traditional versions of the myth.”

¹¹ See for example Fordyce (above, n.7) 281 on v. 19.

¹² Cf. Gaisser (above, n.2) 219; DeBrohun (above, n.4) 300 (“fanfare”).

¹³ For the pictorialism in poem 64, see esp. M. O’Connell, “Pictorialism and Meaning in Catullus 64,” *Latomus* 36 (1977) 746–56.

variant, according to which Thetis achieves a Protean metamorphosis, in order to escape every sexual—or rather this time textual—assault.

As a consequence of the Catullan “poetics of illusion,” the reader cannot decide if he or she should believe in his/her previous knowledge of the mythological tradition, or the narrative content, or rather the visual effects of the Catullan text, which are deconstructing the narrative content itself and reaffirming the traditional variant of the story at the same time. Moreover, this textual effect is deconstructing the ontological status of Thetis, who is being transformed from a fictional—but corporeal—Nereid into a mere name, that is, an alphabetical construct, whose connection to reality depends on the (untruthful) voices of the poet. In this polyptoton, Thetis changes into a kind of textuality, similarly to “Anna Blume,” who in Kurt Schwitters’ poem (*An Anna Blume*) gets into her name in the textual sense of the word:

Weißt du es Anna, weißt du es schon?
 Man kann dich auch von hinten lesen, und du, du
 Herrlichste von allen, du bist von hinten, wie von vorne:
 „a-n-n-a“.

Do you know, Anna, do you know yet?
 You can also be read from back to front, and you, you
 most marvelous creature of them all, you are from the back
 as you are from the front: “a-n-n-a.”¹⁴

In this avant-garde poetic text, Anna is inseparable from her name, the marvelous (*in concreto*, palindromic) nature of which is overwhelming her, changing her “outlook” so much that she finally is “from the back” as she is “from the front”: A-N-N-A. Anna is being literally textualized in Schwitters’ poem, very similarly to the Catullan Thetis, whose marvelous metamorphosis, in a very avant-garde way, is not only a fictional, but also eminently a textual, or rather literal, one. From the viewpoint of the Lucretian *De Rerum Natura*, or rather the Varronian *De Lingua Latina*, the textual Thetis—who is an anagram of herself—seems to be nothing other than an arbitrary configuration of *elementa* (“letters”) like T-H-E-T-I-S, from which you (as an Epicurean *demiurgos*) can compose anything you wish, at least in the textual universe.¹⁵ Thus, Thetis’ morphological metamorphosis can be interpreted as a *mise en abyme* of poem 64, which is a text full of poetic illusions, (mis)leading us in the labyrinth of reading constituted by various narrative, (inter)textual, and visual signals.

EÖTVÖS LORÁND UNIVERSITY
 tamas.abel@btk.elte.hu

¹⁴ Translated by J. Beilharz; see www.jbeilharz.de/expr_poems.html; accessed February 12, 2014.

¹⁵ For the “linguistic” (esp. Varronian) background of the anagrammatism of Roman poets, see F. Ahl, *Metaformations: Soundplay and Wordplay in Ovid and Other Classical Poets* (Ithaca 1985) 17–63.